

Tuesday, 18 August 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Light drizzle 25° 19°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 22° 17°	MANCHESTER Drizzle 19° 16°	GLASGOW Drizzle 17° 14°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

Thousands of parents are at 'breaking point' because of the Child Maintenance Service, according to a new report.

Some parents say they're fighting a constant battle to get ex-partners to pay, while others claim the service has made serious mistakes in calculating what they owe. It's causing huge stress for families across the UK.

FAMILY · UK
- 2

After an exceptional summer of heatwaves, the UK is set for a dramatic change in weather, with rain and much cooler temperatures on the way.

Forecasters are predicting a significant shift, with overnight lows potentially dropping to just 3C in some areas. It's certainly going to feel like autumn has arrived.

WEATHER · UK
- 3

New planning rules coming into force this week will make it harder to convert pubs into homes.

The changes aim to protect local pubs, which are often seen as vital community hubs. It means developers will face more hurdles if they want to change a pub's use.

COMMUNITY · UK
- 4

Reform UK has proposed a ban on most benefits for foreign nationals living in the UK.

The party says this move would require renegotiating the UK's Brexit deal. However, critics warn it could risk stripping British expats in the EU of similar rights.

POLITICS · UK
- 5

Virgin is taking a significant step towards running Channel Tunnel rail services, potentially offering more journeys to Europe.

The company aims to run up to 20 daily services, but still needs additional approval for overseas tracks. It could mean more options for travellers heading to the continent.

TRAVEL · UK

What's coming up

- 1 Big news for Marvel fans: Sadie Sink and Adam Driver are set to star in a new X-Men movie.**

They'll be joined by Kit Connor from 'Heartstopper' and Christopher Abbot, as the Marvel Cinematic Universe continues to expand. It's exciting to see new talent joining the iconic franchise.

ON AIR – What do you make of the new X-Men casting choices? Who would you love to see join the Marvel universe?

FILM · COMING SOON
- 2 Ariana Grande's highly anticipated tour has arrived in the UK, with the star playing the first of ten dates in London.**

After these shows, Ariana has announced she'll be stepping back from public life for a while. So, if you've got tickets, you're in for a treat!

ON AIR – Are you heading to see Ariana Grande on her UK tour? What's your all-time favourite Ariana track?

MUSIC · THIS WEEK
- 3 Ever wondered what really goes on behind the scenes in the MasterChef kitchen? Well, details are emerging from the set of the 21st series.**

The latest series was filmed at Birmingham's Digbeth Loc Studios, and we're getting a glimpse into the pressure and passion of the contestants. Get ready for some culinary drama!

ON AIR – Are you a fan of MasterChef? What's the most ambitious dish you've ever tried to cook at home?

TV · COMING SOON
- 4 Actress Bella Ramsey, known for 'The Last of Us', says she wishes she'd been a more rebellious teenager.**

Bella stars in a new film about a cancer survivor attending 'chemo camp', finding friendship and freedom. It sounds like a really moving story.

ON AIR – Do you ever wish you'd been more rebellious in your youth, or are you glad you played it safe?

FILM · NEW RELEASE
- 5 Eurovision organisers are reportedly proposing new rules to reduce political voting in the contest.**

They say politically motivated voting is 'persistent' and 'deeply worrying'. It's hoped the changes will make the competition fairer and focus more on the music.

ON AIR – Do you think Eurovision needs new rules to tackle political voting, or is it all part of the fun?

MUSIC · FUTURE

On the schedule

1 **British sprint sensation Amy Hunt has cemented her stardom, winning an incredible four gold medals at the European Athletics Championships.**

Hunt's 'iconic quadruple' included victories in the 100m, 200m, 4×100m relay, and the mixed 4×100m relay. She's truly asserted herself as Great Britain's new track star.

ON AIR – What an incredible achievement for Amy Hunt! Who do you think is the most exciting British athlete to watch right now?

ATHLETICS · UK

2 **Manchester City are reportedly in advanced talks to sign Lille midfielder Ayyoub Bouaddi for £85 million.**

City are also still keen on signing Fernandez, as they look to strengthen their squad. It seems like another busy transfer window for the Premier League champions.

ON AIR – Do you think £85 million is a fair price for Bouaddi? Which club do you think has made the best signing so far this summer?

FOOTBALL · UK

3 **Manchester United are reportedly set to reject any bid for their captain, Bruno Fernandes, despite interest from Galatasaray.**

The Turkish club is apparently preparing a bid for the 31-year-old later this week. However, United have no intention of letting their key player go.

ON AIR – Should Manchester United hold onto Bruno Fernandes, or is it time for a change? What's his biggest contribution to the team?

FOOTBALL · UK

4 **Charlie Dean will captain England in their one-day international series against Ireland in September.**

Regular captain Nat Sciver-Brunt is among several senior players being rested. It's a great opportunity for Dean to lead the side.

ON AIR – Are you looking forward to the England vs Ireland series? Who are your favourite players to watch in women's cricket?

CRICKET · UK

5 **The Manchester Super Giants have claimed their first Hundred title, beating Trent Rockets by five wickets in the men's final at Lord's.**

Tim Seifert was the star of the show, smashing 72 off just 38 balls to power the Super Giants to victory. What a thrilling end to the tournament!

ON AIR – Did you follow The Hundred this year? What do you think of the tournament compared to other forms of cricket?

CRICKET · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A new study suggests that 'hugging a tree' can actually reduce stress and improve your mood.**
Researchers found that the physical act of embracing a tree, even for a few moments, can release endorphins and create a sense of calm. It's a natural way to ground yourself.
- 2 The delightful art of 'making miniature gardens' in teacups or small pots is blooming across the country.**
People are creating tiny landscapes with moss, pebbles, and tiny plants, bringing a touch of whimsical nature indoors. It's a lovely, calming hobby for any age.
- 3 Scientists have discovered that 'listening to birdsong' can significantly boost feelings of happiness and well-being.**
Even just a few minutes of natural birdsong can reduce anxiety and increase positive emotions, proving nature's soundtrack is incredibly powerful.
- 4 A charming trend sees people 'swapping homemade jams and preserves' with their neighbours and friends.**
It's a wonderful way to share seasonal flavours and build community spirit, ensuring no delicious fruit goes to waste.
- 5 New research indicates that 'spending time near water' – like a river, lake, or the sea – can improve mental clarity and reduce stress.**
The sound and sight of water have a naturally soothing effect, making waterside walks incredibly beneficial for our minds.
- 6 The humble 'picnic blanket' is seeing a resurgence as families embrace outdoor dining and relaxation.**
From local parks to garden spaces, people are rediscovering the simple joy of spreading out a blanket and enjoying a meal al fresco.
- 7 A fascinating study reveals that 'reading a physical book' before bed can lead to better sleep than looking at a screen.**
The absence of blue light and the tactile experience of a book help prepare the brain for rest, promoting a more peaceful night.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what with our perfectly good socks, even though we know we should probably just throw them away?

ANSWER: KEEPING THE SINGLE ONES, JUST IN CASE THEIR LOST PARTNER EVENTUALLY REAPPEARS!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a lovely, fresh slice of toast. What is it?

ANSWER: CUTTING IT DIAGONALLY, EVERY SINGLE TIME!

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes a particular 'shop or cafe from your childhood' holds really special memories for you?

What's a local business from your younger days that you still think about fondly, and why does it stick in your mind? Give us a call!

- We all have those 'little tricks' or methods we use to make everyday chores just a tiny bit more enjoyable, don't we?

What's your secret for making a mundane task, like doing the washing up or tidying, feel a bit less of a chore? We'd love to hear your ingenious ideas!

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** Did you know, a group of owls is called a 'parliament'?

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Did you know, a group of butterflies is called a 'kaleidoscope'?

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£4.3 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£4.3 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The world's oldest known living tree is over 5,000 years old and is located in California.
- A 'tsunami' can travel across the ocean at the speed of a jet plane.
- The average cloud weighs around 550 tons, roughly the same as 100 elephants.
- Bumblebees can fly higher than Mount Everest.
- The 'richest' soil on Earth is called 'chernozem', found in Eastern Europe and Russia.
- The British Library in London holds over 170 million items.
- The first traffic lights were installed in London in 1868, just outside the Houses of Parliament.
- The 'tingle' you feel when your foot falls asleep is called paresthesia.

On this day

Day 230 of the year, 135 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Agapitus of Palestrina; Christian feast day: Alberto Hurtado; Christian feast day: Daig of Inniskeen; Christian feast day: Evan (or Inan). Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1969 — Edward Norton, American actor
- 1994 — Madelaine Petsch, American actress and YouTuber
- 1943 — Martin Mull, American actor and comedian (died 2024)
- 1988 — Jack Hobbs, English footballer
- 1971 — Richard David James, English musician and record producer
- 1957 — Tan Dun, Chinese composer
- 1936 — Robert Redford, American actor, director, and producer (died 2025)
- 1942 — Henry G. Sanders, American actor

THE DAY TODAY

- 1950 — Julien Lahaut, the chairman of the Communist Party of Belgium, is assassinated. The Party newspaper blames royalists and Rexists.
- 1963 — Civil rights movement: James Meredith becomes the first African American to graduate from the University of Mississippi.
- 1945 — Soviet-Japanese War: Battle of Shumshu: Soviet forces land at Takeda Beach on Shumshu Island and launch the Battle of Shumshu; the Soviet Union's Invasion of the Kuril Islands commences.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1977 — Steve Biko is arrested at a police roadblock under Terrorism Act No. 83 of 1967 in King William's Town, South Africa. He later dies from injuries sustained during this arrest, bringing attention to South Africa's apartheid policies.
- 2003 — One-year-old Zachary Turner is murdered in Newfoundland by his mother, who was awarded custody despite facing trial for the murder of Zachary's father. The case was documented in the film Dear Zachary and led to reform of Canada's bail laws.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1983 — Hurricane Alicia hits the Texas coast, killing 21 people and causing over US\$1 billion in damage (1983 dollars).

- 1937 — A lightning strike starts the Blackwater Fire of 1937 in Shoshone National Forest, killing 15 firefighters within three days and prompting the United States Forest Service to develop their smokejumper program.
- 2008 — War of Afghanistan: The Uzbin Valley ambush occurs.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 231 of the year, 134 days left in 2026. Today Afghan Independence Day, commemorates the Treaty of Rawalpindi in 1919, granting independence from Britain (Afghanistan); August Revolution Commemoration Day (Vietnam); Birthday of Crown Princess Mette-Marit (Norway); Christian Feast Day: Bertulf of Bobbio. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1961 — Jonathan Coe, English author and academic
- 1969 — Nate Dogg, American rapper (died 2011)
- 1965 — Kevin Dillon, American actor
- 1982 — Erika Christensen, American actress
- 1946 — Dawn Steel, American film producer (died 1997)
- 1975 — Tracie Thoms, American actress
- 1980 — Darius Campbell, Scottish singer-songwriter, guitarist, and actor (died 2022)
- 1959 — Ivan Neville, American singer-songwriter

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2003 — A truck-bomb attack on United Nations headquarters in Iraq kills the agency's top envoy Sérgio Vieira de Mello and 21 other employees.
- 1964 — Syncom 3, the first geostationary communication satellite, is launched. Two months later, it would enable live coverage of the 1964 Summer Olympics.
- 1980 — Saudia Flight 163, a Lockheed L-1011 TriStar burns after making an emergency landing at Riyadh International Airport in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, killing 301 people.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2010 — Operation Iraqi Freedom ends, with the last of the United States brigade combat teams crossing the border to Kuwait.
- 1989 — Several hundred East Germans cross the frontier between Hungary and Austria during the Pan-European Picnic, part of the events that began the process of the Fall of the Berlin Wall.

Coming to cinemas

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome
SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)
OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

11 — FORWARD PLANNING • SPORT

On the sporting calendar

AUGUST 2026

22–23

Belgian Grand Prix (F1)